

Zimbabwe 2.0: AI for National Transformation 2026

“Leveraging AI for Innovation, Policy, and Inclusive National Development”

1. Introduction

Zimbabwe is emerging as a digitally capable nation, ready to harness artificial intelligence for sustainable economic growth. The country’s telecommunications penetration has expanded significantly, creating connectivity that enables digital transformation across urban and rural areas. Innovation hubs at universities and research institutions are generating AI-ready talent and solutions, while national programs in healthcare, agriculture, finance, and public services increasingly require AI integration to optimize efficiency and impact. The informal economy, which forms a substantial part of Zimbabwe’s GDP, stands to benefit from AI-enabled solutions for market intelligence, logistics, and financial inclusion.

With these developments, Zimbabwe is AI-ready, but scaling up requires strategic investment in national AI infrastructure, high-performance compute, data readiness (public and private), skills development, and funding mechanisms. Leveraging AI effectively will not only enhance domestic economic growth but also strengthen Zimbabwe’s role within SADC and the broader African AI ecosystem, enabling regional leadership in digital innovation, data governance, and AI-driven competitiveness.

2. Preamble.

Artificial intelligence represents a transformative force capable of accelerating Zimbabwe’s long-term development aspirations. Anchored in **Vision 2030**, the country has defined ambitious targets for economic diversification, innovation, and inclusivity. **NDS2** operationalizes these ambitions, identifying priority sectors where AI can enhance productivity and governance.

The adoption of the **National AI Policy** provides a robust framework for ethical, accountable, and strategic AI deployment across public and private sectors. Complementing this framework, Zimbabwe has achieved progress in data protection laws, ensuring citizen privacy and trust in digital systems, and strengthened cybersecurity measures to safeguard national digital infrastructure. These foundational elements position the country to adopt AI at scale while minimizing risks and ensuring alignment with national development objectives.

3. Purpose of the Conference

The **Zimbabwe 2.0: AI for National Transformation 2026** conference aims to:

1. Promote Zimbabwe’s readiness for AI adoption and identify strategies to scale deployment across sectors.
2. Foster multi-sectoral collaboration to implement **Vision 2030**, **NDS2 priorities**, and the **National AI Policy** through AI-driven initiatives.

3. Objectives

- 3.1. Assess Zimbabwe's AI readiness, including digital infrastructure, telecom coverage, innovation hubs, and sectoral preparedness.
- 3.2. Explore strategies to build national AI infrastructure, including AI compute capacity and platforms for high-performance AI workloads.
- 3.3. Identify methods for preparing public and private data for AI adoption, ensuring quality, accessibility, and ethical use.
- 3.4. Discuss solutions for skills, capacity building, and knowledge transfer to support national AI initiatives.
- 3.5. Examine funding mechanisms and investment strategies to accelerate AI deployment
- 3.6. Showcase AI innovations and research outputs from universities, startups, and industry
- 3.7. Promote AI inclusive growth, ensuring no one and no place is left behind
- 3.8. Highlight Zimbabwe's progress in data protection, cybersecurity, and digital infrastructure
- 3.9. Explore sector-specific AI applications in health, agriculture, finance, education, and public services.

4. Areas to be Covered

- 4.1. AI in Agriculture, Food Security, Healthcare and Public Health
- 4.2. Mining, Industry, Financial services and Inclusive Digital Economy
- 4.3. Education, Skills Development and AI Capacity Building
- 4.4. Digital Infrastructure and National AI Platforms
- 4.5. Data Governance, Ethics and Policy
- 4.6. Cybersecurity and AI-Enabled Risk Management
- 4.7. Innovation, Entrepreneurship and AI Startups
- 4.8. Sustainable Development and Climate Action

5. Who Should Attend

The conference targets:

- Government policymakers and regulators shaping technology, innovation, and development agendas.
- Captains of Industry and professionals
- Academia and researchers advancing AI knowledge, applications, and policy.
- Technology entrepreneurs and startups driving AI innovation.
- Civil society organizations advocating for ethical, inclusive AI.
- International partners and investors supporting Zimbabwe's AI ecosystem.

6. Event Details

- 6.1. Dates: May 2026
- 6.2. Venue: Nyanga

7. Conference Organisers – Zimpapers and the Artificial Intelligence Institute Africa (AiiA)